Lesson 2 Worksheet — The Marshmallow Challenge

"A Lesson in Keeping It Simple"

CEFR B2 | Name: _____ Class / No.: _____

Vocabulary Reference List

Words for Production

#	Word	詞性	中文	衍生詞
1	**innovative**	*adj.*	創新的	innovate (vi. 創新); innovation (n. 新方法)
2	**promise**	*vt./vi./n.*	可望；預示；承諾	
3	**material**	*n. [C]*	（活動所需的）材料	
4	**mention**	*vt.*	提到	
5	**structure**	*n. [C]*	結構體；建築物	
6	**capable**	*adj.*	有能力的；能夠的	capability (n. 能力)
7	**collaborate**	*vi.*	合作	collaboration (n. 合作)
8	**architect**	*n. [C]*	建築師	architecture (n. 建築)
9	**graduate**	*n. [C] / vi.*	（大學）畢業生；畢業	graduation (n. 畢業)
10	**construct**	*vt.*	建造	construction (n. 建築物；建造); constructive (adj. 有建設性的)
11	**slightly**	*adv.*	稍微	slight (adj. 細微的)
12	**rank**	*vi./vt.*	排序為	ranking (n. 排名)
13	**unique**	*adj.*	獨特的	
14	**adjust**	*vt.*	調整	adjustment (n. 調整)
15	**rely**	*vi.*	依賴；信任	reliable (adj. 可信賴的)
16	**feedback**	*n. [U]*	回饋意見	
17	**element**	*n. [C]*	要素	elementary (adj. 初級的；基礎的)
18	**stability**	*n. [U]*	穩定	stable (adj. 穩定的；穩固的)
19	**route**	*n. [C]*	途徑；路線	
20	**explore**	*vt.*	探索	exploration (n. 探索；探究)

Idioms and Phrases

trial and error 反覆試驗 — an approach that aims to arrive at the best solution by trying different things and eliminating what doesn't work

in charge 主控；負責 — to be in a higher position that gives one power or control over others

figure out 想出 — to work out; to find the answer or solution to a problem

roll up one's sleeves 挽起袖子（表示開始行動） — to get ready to work hard or do what is needed, usually without question or complaint

get down to... 開始做某事 — to start to do something with a lot of effort or attention

Words for Recognition

marshmallow (n. [C, U] 棉花糖) ｜ Tom Wujec (n. 湯姆．伍傑克) ｜ CEO (n. [C] 行政總裁；首席執行長) ｜ kindergartener (n. [C] 幼稚園生) ｜ outperform (vt. （在操作或性能上）勝過)

Dialogue — Talking About the Marshmallow Challenge

Every bold + underlined word below is one of this lesson's 20 Words for Production. Use the surrounding context to work out each meaning.

Leo: You won't believe what we did at the workshop yesterday — it's called the Marshmallow Challenge.

Emma: Wait, isn't that the one where teams build a tower out of spaghetti and tape?

Leo: Exactly. Our trainer explained the rules, and honestly, at first our group just **relied** on guessing instead of any real plan, and it showed.

Emma: What happened?

Leo: Our first **structure** kept collapsing. We spent way too much time arguing about the design instead of just building something.

Emma: Sounds stressful. Did the trainer **mention** why some teams do better than others?

Leo: Yeah, she said the groups that **collaborate** right away, without wasting time on who's in charge, usually win.

Emma: Makes sense. Teamwork over planning, I guess.

Leo: Right. She also said the activity **promised** to reveal a lot about how a team actually works together, not just on paper.

Emma: Interesting. So who ended up winning?

Leo: A group of interns, believe it or not. None of them were engineers or **capable** of anything technical, but they just started building immediately.

Emma: That's kind of the whole point, isn't it? Like how kids beat adults in the original study.

Leo: Exactly, and once they saw their first attempt wasn't working, they quickly **adjusted** it instead of sticking to a broken plan.

Emma: Smart. A pretty **unique** way to think about problem-solving.

Leo: Definitely. Even one of the **architects** on our team said afterward that watching them work gave her a lot of **feedback** about her own habits at the office.

Emma: That's a great insight for someone who literally **constructs** buildings for a living.

Leo: Right? Meanwhile the “expert” team, made up of engineering **graduates**, actually **ranked** near the bottom.

Emma: Really? Why?

Leo: They spent too much time planning and ended up **slightly** behind almost every other group.

Emma: Ha, overthinking strikes again.

Leo: The trainer said the biggest **element** of success wasn't skill at all — it was speed and flexibility.

Emma: What **materials** did you even use, by the way?

Leo: Just spaghetti sticks, tape, string, and a marshmallow. Nothing fancy, but somehow it's incredibly hard to make something with real **stability**.

Emma: I can imagine. It probably falls apart if the base isn't strong enough.

Leo: Exactly. Anyway, the trainer's whole point was that being **innovative** doesn't always mean coming up with a fancy idea — sometimes it just means trying something and fixing it fast.

Emma: That's actually a really good lesson for my study group too. We keep planning our project and never actually start.

Leo: Maybe it's time you guys **explore** a “just start building” **route** instead.

Emma: Ha, you might be right.

Word Bank (order of appearance): rely • structure • mention • collaborate • promise • capable • adjust • unique • architect • feedback • construct • graduate • rank • slightly • element • material • innovative • stability • route • explore

Comprehension & Inference Questions

Part A — Short-Answer Comprehension & Inference

Answer each question in one to three complete sentences, based on the reading passage.

1. (Comprehension) According to the passage, which two groups performed the best in the Marshmallow Challenge, and how did their results compare?

2. (Comprehension) According to the passage, what does the "trial and error" approach actually give kindergarteners, and how does this help them build a taller structure?

3. (Inference) Why do you think business graduates performed the worst, despite spending a lot of time creating "the best plan"?

4. (Inference) The author states that the Marshmallow Challenge teaches us that "age and experience are not the only routes to success." What evidence from the passage supports this claim?

Part B — Extended Response (about 100 words each)

Write a well-organized paragraph of approximately 100 words for each question. Support your ideas with reasons or examples.

5. Based on the passage, do you think careful planning or quick action is more important for success in a task like the Marshmallow Challenge? Explain, using details from the passage to support your view.

6. The author concludes that to solve problems, “we must roll up our sleeves and get down to work right away, explore and experiment with new ideas, and collaborate effectively.” Do you agree that this approach works for real-life problems, not just building towers? Support your opinion with an example.

Sentence Pattern & Translation Practice

Target Pattern 1 (Sentence Pattern): not...until... (something doesn't happen until something else happens first)
Target Pattern 2 (Language in Use): that/those of (used to avoid repeating a singular/plural noun when comparing two things)

Part C — Sentence-Combining / Substitution Drill

1. (Pattern 1: not...until...) Rewrite the sentence using "not...until...".

- Leo's team only started building once they realized talking wouldn't help.

2. (Pattern 2: that/those of) Combine the two sentences into one, using "that/those of" to avoid repeating the noun.

- Leo's team's final structure was much taller.
- Most other teams' structures were shorter.

Part D — Chinese–English Translation (GSAT-style)

Translate the following sentences into English. Use the word(s) given in parentheses.

1. (Pattern 1) 這個團隊直到失敗了好幾次之後，才調整了原本的設計。(not...until; adjust)

2. (Pattern 2) 幼稚園生蓋的結構比大多數大人的結構都還要高。(those; structure)